The British Government accepted the Poona Pact and modified the Communal Award in respect to the depressed classes (Scheduled Castes). This means that the provisions of separate electorates for the depressed classes were dropped from the scheme of representation contained in the Communal Award. Subsequently, the provisions of the Poona Pact were incorporated in the next Government of India Act of 1935. In other words, the composition of the central and provincial legislatures under the 1935 Act was based on this modified Communal Award.



Government of India Act of 1935

The Act marked a second milestone towards a completely responsible government in India. It was a lengthy and detailed document having 321 Sections and 10 Schedules.

The features of this Act were as follows:

1. It provided for the establishment of an All-India Federation consisting of provinces and princely states as units. The Act divided the powers between the Centre and units in terms of three lists—**Federal List** (for Centre, with 59 items), **Provincial List** (for provinces, with 54 items) and the Concurrent List (for both, with 36 items). Residuary powers were given to the Viceroy (Governor-General). However, the federation never came into being as the princely states did not join it.

2. It abolished dyarchy in the provinces and introduced 'provincial autonomy' in its place. The provinces were allowed to act as autonomous units of administration in their defined spheres. Moreover, the Act introduced responsible Governments in provinces, that is, the Governor was required to act with the advice of ministers responsible to the provincial legislature. This came into effect in 1937 and was discontinued in 1939.

3. It provided for the adoption of dyarchy at the Centre. Consequently, the federal subjects were divided into reserved subjects and transferred subjects. However, this provision of the Act did not come into operation at all.

4. It introduced bicameralism in six out of eleven provinces. Thus, the legislatures of Bengal, Bombay, Madras, Bihar, Assam and the United Provinces were made bicameral consisting of a legislative council (upper house) and a legislative assembly (lower house). However, many restrictions were placed on them.

5. It reserved a certain number of general seats for the depressed classes (Scheduled Castes). It also extended the special representation to women and labour (workers).

6. It abolished the Council of India, established by the Government of India Act of 1858. The secretary of state for India was provided with a team of advisors.

7. It extended franchise. About 14 per cent of the total population got the voting right.

8. It provided for the establishment of a Reserve Bank of India to control the currency and credit of the country.